We might have only recently won the Treble. We might have been going into a new season believing we could do it again. But never mind all that: the manager was going to make sure that nobody started taking anything for granted. He was probably trying to bring me back down to earth: I'd just lived through the most amazing six months of my life, feeling like things couldn't be going any better, at Old Trafford or at home. If he'd asked me, I'd have told the boss I didn't need the abuse he gave me at the start of pre-season. I suppose it's always been part of how things are done at United: any hint of anybody getting above themselves and someone—a team-mate, a member of staff or the manager himself—was there to knock you down again. I didn't think it was right, but I understood why the boss had reacted the way he did. As always, he was doing what he thought was best for the team. There was only one thing for me to do: knuckle down and get on with it.

Since that memorable semi-final against Arsenal, the team had felt invincible: we went into every single game sure that we'd win it. And that confidence rolled on into the new 1999/2000 season. We made a great start and, for the next nine months, hardly looked back. Even the odd defeat—I remember we got thrashed 5–0 at Chelsea—didn't stop the momentum. As happy as I was at home, I was even happier to be playing soccer—for United and for England, too. After France 98, even at the lowest of times, I hadn't ever wondered about continuing to play for my country. I'd never thought about stopping even if that might have been a way of easing the pressure on me. My only doubts were about whether, in the long run, I had an England future under Glenn Hoddle. I always had the feeling that he'd have looked for a way, sooner or later, to leave me out of his plans.

Back in the autumn of 1998, we'd made a pretty poor start to qualifying for the next European Championships. England supporters weren't happy and some of the media seemed to be campaigning for a change of manager. Even so, when that change happened, and the way it happened, it came as a real shock. I don't know how much of it all was Glenn's fault and how much he was betrayed by the press. When I first heard that he'd been quoted talking about disabled people and their past lives, I knew straight away it was going to turn into something huge. Overnight, it seemed that everybody, including the Prime Minister, was having a say on it. Once they're in the headlines, stories move so quickly that no one really has a chance to think. At the start of February, just a few days after the interview had been published, Glenn was gone. There was a crazy press conference to announce it at the FA, where one England fan had to be dragged out kicking and screaming. Despite the fact I'd had real differences with him as England manager, I knew that must have been a very hard afternoon for Glenn.